TEACHER COPY · VERSION A · the key is in bold, with why under each answer

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version A

Grade 7 · English / Reading · Making inferences and citing text evidence (fiction and nonfiction)

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. For multiple choice, fill in the circle next to the best answer. For the others, write on the lines.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. In paragraph 4, what does Tam think is the reason Biscuit stays away? L1 · infer a character's feelings or beliefs

A. Biscuit misses Mrs. Abara and wants her back.

B. Kiran is making too much noise.

C. Biscuit is shy with every new person.

D. Biscuit has decided she does not like Kiran.

Answer: **B. Kiran is making too much noise.**
Why: Tam answers Kiran's two ideas with "Or you're loud" [4]. Missing Mrs. Abara and "she hates me" are Kiran's own ideas [4], and Tam's "Or" offers a different reason; "shy with new people" is Mrs. Abara's warning [1], not Tam's view.

2. On Wednesday evening, why does Kiran most likely sit down on the floor against the couch? L2 · infer why a character acts

A. He plans to stay quiet so that Biscuit will come out to him.

B. He is too worn out from singing to keep going.

C. He has schoolwork he needs to get done.

D. He hopes the feather toy he left by the couch will draw her out.

Answer: **C. He has schoolwork he needs to get done.**
Why: He "had a math test to study for," so he sat down and opened his notebook [5]. Staying quiet to draw her out is ruled out: he "forgot to call her at all" [5], so he was not trying anything; he had "no energy for singing" that evening [5]; no toy is in [5]-[6], and he did nothing to draw her out [5].

3. In paragraph 7, Kiran starts to say something to Mrs. Abara and then stops. What has he most likely just figured out? L3 · infer what a character realizes

A. Biscuit had eaten the Monday food herself.

B. Mrs. Abara came home early that day.

C. Dev was supposed to come by that day.

D. The bowl tipped over behind the mat.

Answer: **A. Biscuit had eaten the Monday food herself.**
Why: Two steps: on Monday Kiran decided Dev "must have come by and tossed it out" [3], but the note says Dev comes Thursday [1], and Kiran stops right after looking at Dev on Thursday [7]. So nobody threw the food out; Biscuit ate it. Mrs. Abara gets home on Thursday, while Dev is watering the plants [7], not on Monday; the note never asked Dev to come on Monday: it says "Dev will come Thursday" [1]; Kiran "looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled" [3].

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4. Why does the author tell us, in paragraph 1, how long Kiran had been asking for a pet? L2 · infer why the author includes a detail

A. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a dull chore

B. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a test he means to ace

C. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a contest with Dev over who she likes best

D. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a skill he has already mastered

Answer: **B. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a test he means to ace**
Why: The next sentence says the four days "felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score" [1]. Not a chore to rush: he "tried harder" on Tuesday [4]; not a contest with Dev: Dev only comes on Thursday [1], [7], when the four days are over; not a skill he has mastered: his calling, tapping, toy and singing all fail [2], [4].

5. On Tuesday, what does Kiran try, and how does Biscuit respond? Quote the sentence that shows how she responds, and give its paragraph number. L2 · cite evidence for a claim

Answer: **He waves a feather toy under the bed and sings; she watches him and then moves away: "Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away." [4]**
Why: Full credit: the toy or the singing, her watching and then slipping away, and the [4] sentence with [4]. An answer like "she hides" or "she ignores him" with no line from [4] earns at most half credit.

The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

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5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

Questions 6-10: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, who first found out what was happening to the new shoots?

L1 · find a detail in the text

A. Tomas Brill, a fisherman

B. a group of students

C. Hana Selk, a teacher

D. a scientist from the mainland

Answer: **C. Hana Selk, a teacher**

Why: "In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk" tested the water and then went out after dark and saw what was happening [4]. The fishermen only appear as glad the drells left [2] and in the catch [7]; the students came later and built platforms [5]; [4] names Selk, and no visiting scientist is in the article.

7. Why did the South Lagoon most likely keep most of its reeds in the 1961 storm?

L2 · infer a cause the text does not spell out

A. It sat behind higher land that blocked the storm.

B. Thick reeds broke up the waves first.

C. Tougher reeds grew on that shore.

D. Rain and wind missed that side of the island.

Answer: **A. It sat behind higher land that blocked the storm.**

Why: The South Lagoon was "behind higher dunes" and "lost only a few" [2]: the dunes sheltered it. Thick reeds grew along both shores [1], and the North's were flattened anyway [2], so thick reeds did not shelter a lagoon; tolla reeds grew along both shores [1], the same kind in both lagoons; it lost a few reeds [2], so the storm did reach it.

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8. Based on the article, why did the North Lagoon's reeds stay away after 1961, when they had come back after smaller storms? L3 · trace a cause-and-effect chain

A. This storm left salt in the water that never washed out.

B. This storm spoiled the mud the old roots grew in.

C. This storm left the new shoots with no shelter from the cold.

D. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.

Answer: **D. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.**
Why: Two steps: after 1961 the drells flew off [2]; drells eat kib snails [1], and without drells "almost nothing was eating the kibs," which ate the new shoots to the roots [4]; so shoots that came up each spring were gone each summer [3]. Selk found the water no saltier than the South's [4]; green shoots "poked up from the mud" every spring [3], so the mud and roots still grew shoots; the cold did not stop them either: shoots came up every spring [3], and Selk saw kib snails eating them [4].

9. In paragraph 5, the islanders' first plan for the North Lagoon does not work. What does the author want readers to understand from that? L3 · infer what the author wants readers to think

A. New reeds would not last until the salt washed out.

B. New reeds would not last until young fish stopped nibbling the roots.

C. New reeds would not last until fishermen stopped trampling the shore.

D. New reeds would not last until fewer snails were left to eat them.

Answer: **D. New reeds would not last until fewer snails were left to eat them.**
Why: Two steps: the reeds planted by hand failed because "The snails ate those too" [5], and without drells "almost nothing was eating the kibs" [4]; only when the snails were "thinner on the mud" did reeds stand again [6]. Selk found the water "no saltier than the South's" [4], and [5] says snails ate the planted reeds; young fish "hide among reed stems" [7], and [5] names the snails, not fish; [5] says the snails ate the planted reeds, and no trampling is in the article.

10. What does "thinner" mean as it is used in paragraph 6? Quote a sentence from an earlier paragraph that helps show the meaning, and give its paragraph number. L2 · word meaning from context, with evidence

Answer: **Fewer and more spread out, not crowded: "The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots." [4]**
Why: Half credit: a meaning like "fewer / less crowded" ("skinnier" is the everyday sense and does not fit). The other half: the [4] sentence about the crowded mud, with [4]. A meaning with no line from the passage earns at most half credit.

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CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

11. How does Kiran change from the beginning of "Biscuit" to the end? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer. L3 · infer how a character changes (RACE)

> A strong answer: **Kiran changes from trying hard and loudly to win Biscuit over to being calm and letting her come to him. At first he taps the bowl "louder each time" [2]. Later he "did not reach for her" [6], and he asks to come back with his homework [7].**
>
> Why: Score with the RACE CHECKLIST. Strong evidence: [1], [2] or [4] for the start; [5], [6] or [7] for the end. The Explain row needs how each quote shows the change.

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Skills and level map

Each question's skill and level (1 = on-ramp, 2 = on level, 3 = harder, often two steps). Version A and B test the same skill at the same level, question for question.

Level 1: 2 (18%)	**Level 2**: 5 (45%)	**Level 3**: 4 (36%)

Skill	Questions	How many
infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	1
infer why a character acts	2	1
infer what a character realizes	3	1
infer why the author includes a detail	4	1
cite evidence for a claim	5	1
find a detail in the text	6	1
infer a cause the text does not spell out	7	1
trace a cause-and-effect chain	8	1
infer what the author wants readers to think	9	1
word meaning from context, with evidence	10	1
infer how a character changes (RACE)	11	1

#	Skill	Level	Type	Key (version A)
1	infer a character's feelings or beliefs	1	mc	**B. Kiran is making too much noise.**
2	infer why a character acts	2	mc	**C. He has schoolwork he needs to get done.**
3	infer what a character realizes	3	mc	**A. Biscuit had eaten the Monday food herself.**
4	infer why the author includes a detail	2	mc	**B. to explain why Kiran treats four days with Biscuit as a test he means to ace**
5	cite evidence for a claim	2	short	**He waves a feather toy under the bed and sings; she watches him and then moves away: "Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away." [4]**
6	find a detail in the text	1	mc	**C. Hana Selk, a teacher**

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7	infer a cause the text does not spell out	2	mc	**A. It sat behind higher land that blocked the storm.**
8	trace a cause-and-effect chain	3	mc	**D. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.**
9	infer what the author wants readers to think	3	mc	**D. New reeds would not last until fewer snails were left to eat them.**
10	word meaning from context, with evidence	2	short	**Fewer and more spread out, not crowded: "The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots." [4]**
11	infer how a character changes (RACE)	3	open	**Kiran changes from trying hard and loudly to win Biscuit over to being calm and letting her come to him. At first he taps the bowl "louder each time" [2]. Later he "did not reach for her" [6], and he asks to come back with his homework [7].**

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